

# Roommate Payment Agreement templates, legal eviction prep checklists, financial protection guides — Action Checklist

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## CREATE WRITTEN FINANCIAL AGREEMENTS

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- ☐ **Draft a Payment Hierarchy Agreement:** Create a one-page Payment Hierarchy Agreement that specifies payment order, exact due dates with times, grace period length, and concrete late payment consequences so both parties have clear, documented expectations from the start.
- ☐ **Have Both Roommates Sign and Exchange Copies:** Print two signed copies of your Payment Hierarchy Agreement and exchange them with your roommate, keeping one in a safe location so you're protected if disputes arise later about what was actually agreed to.
- ☐ **Define Payment Order for Limited Funds:** Specify a clear payment order for situations when money is tight—rent first, then utilities, then shared household items—so both roommates know exactly which bills take priority when cash is short.
- ☐ **Quantify Late Payment Consequences Upfront:** Establish a specific late fee amount and timeline (such as \$25 flat fee plus interest after 15 days) before problems occur, making the cost of lateness visible so you're not forced to negotiate consequences in the moment.

## SET UP FINANCIAL PROTECTION SYSTEMS

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- ☐ **Open a Separate Joint Rent Account:** Open a dedicated checking account at your current bank or credit union specifically for rent payments, separating it from personal finances so all rent money flows through a neutral account that's clearly labeled for this purpose.
  - ☐ **Automate Transfers 5-7 Days Before Rent Due:** Configure automatic transfers from each roommate's personal accounts to the joint rent account 5-7 days before the actual rent due date, creating a processing buffer that prevents last-minute payment scrambles.
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- **Document All Financial Agreements in Writing:** Convert every verbal financial agreement into a written, dated record—emails, texts, or formal documents—so you have verifiable evidence of what was actually promised if your roommate's memory differs from yours later.
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- **Create a Lease Addendum with Your Landlord:** Draft a formal lease addendum that supplements your original rental agreement with specific financial arrangements, then have both roommates and your landlord sign it to establish legal enforceability beyond the basic lease terms.

## ENFORCE BOUNDARIES AND KNOW LEGAL OPTIONS

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- **Start the Direct Money Conversation Immediately:** Initiate a straightforward conversation with your roommate about the money owed and payment expectations before the situation deteriorates further, using your signed Payment Hierarchy Agreement as the foundation for that discussion.
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- **Maintain Comprehensive Payment Records:** Keep detailed records of every Venmo transfer, cash payment, and written communication about money including dates, amounts, and any promises made, building the paper trail you'll need for legal protection.
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- **Research Local Tenant Laws and Eviction Procedures:** Investigate your local tenant laws and formal eviction procedures so you understand your rights and options if your roommate consistently fails to pay, giving you confidence to take action when necessary.
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- **Prepare Legal Documentation as Your Backup Plan:** Compile eviction checklists, demand letters, and other legal documentation so you have exit options ready, knowing that having these tools available often makes enforcing boundaries easier without needing to actually use them.
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